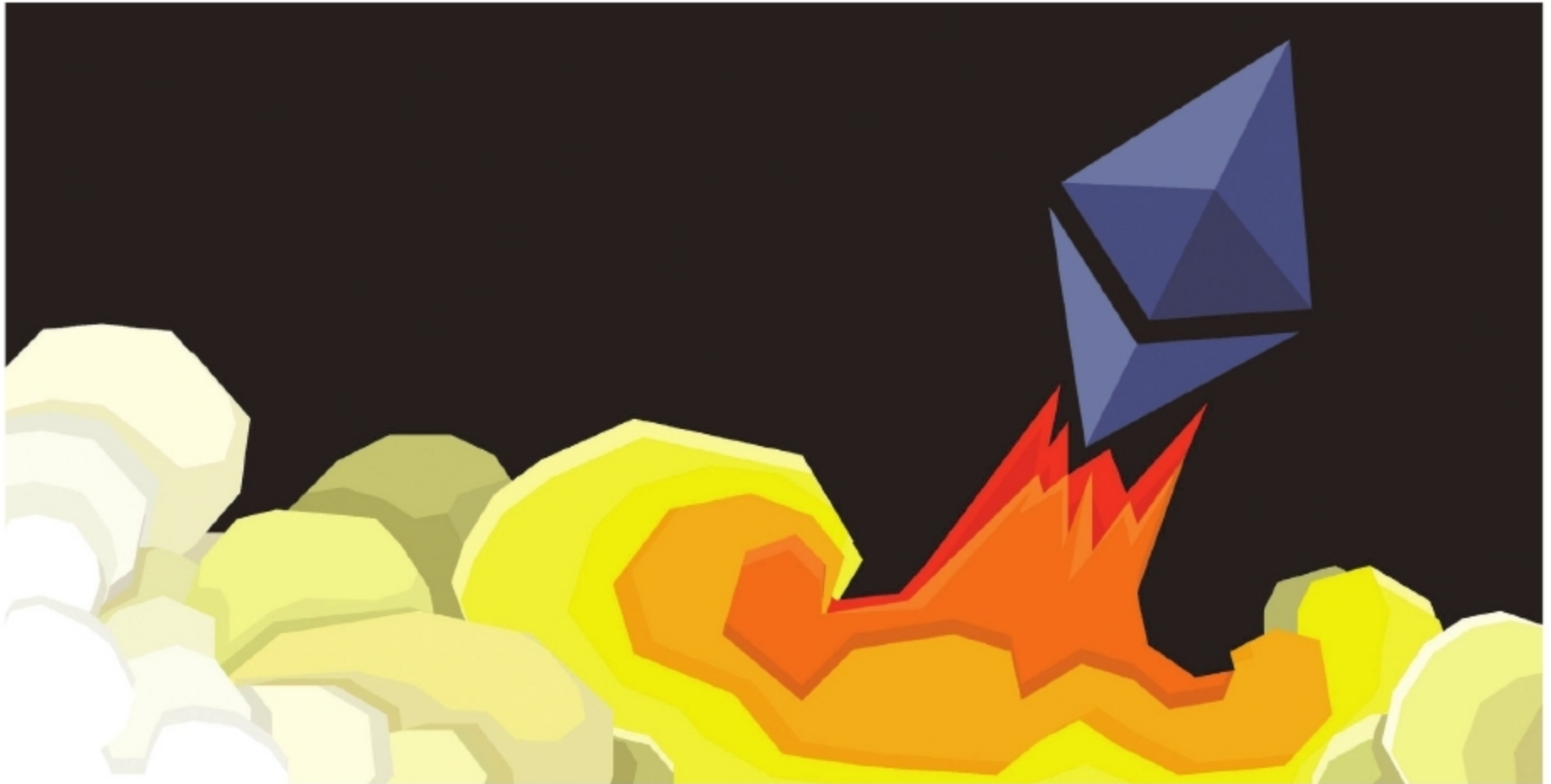


The Ethereum Saga

This article describes the origins and rise of Ethereum. The ups and downs in the journey of this blockchain make for interesting reading. Ethereum's unique versatility is also covered.



The last two years have been literally a roller coaster ride for cryptocurrencies, with the boom and burst of entities from the USA to China. Bitcoin prices soaring to over US\$ 16,000 prompted the world to take notice of the silently growing wave of technologies built on the concept of a blockchain. Top CEOs and consortiums of banks reversed their earlier reluctant stances and scrambled to create their own digital ledgers and cryptocurrency-inspired products. We saw tech companies strike deals to introduce their own crypto products with existing currencies, which then saw their valuations soar to heights only dreamt of before. It was a bubble that burst pretty quickly and many companies had to down the shutters on their cryptocurrencies. But others sustained themselves through this rise and fall, to a less volatile state.

On the bright side, this cycle led to widespread awareness and a general consensus on there being huge scope for maintaining a public ledger, as companies started investigating potential applications within their own technology stacks. This is when a 19-year old made waves in the community when he came up with the idea of expanding the technology underlying cryptocurrencies to support multi-faceted applications, based on blockchain's system of consensus and public ledgers.



Figure 1: Ethereum co-founder Vitalik Buterin
(Source: CryptoNewsZ)

The history of Ethereum

Vitalik Buterin had been intrigued by the blockchain since he was 17 years old. He first got involved as a programmer with Bitcoin in 2011, and then went on to found Bitcoin Magazine. His interest culminated in the release of a white paper two years later, which served as the foundation of a technology he launched, called Ethereum. The name, as Buterin stated, came from a search of Wikipedia articles about elements and science fiction, following which he arrived at this term that included 'ether', the hypothetical invisible medium that permeates the universe.

The idea behind Ethereum was to reimagine the use cases for a blockchain, beyond just finance. Ethereum provided a platform for trading that went beyond the role of a plain old cryptocurrency by utilising